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The Feminization of Generative AI: Gender Delegation Through Names and Personas

Nigam Dave, Shrishti Kushwah¹

1. Research Scholar- Pandit Deendayal Energy University

Abstract

AI voice assistants and chatbots are overwhelmingly given feminine personas – by feminine names, female voices, and caregiving personas. This paper analyzes the gendering of generative AI systems with explicit (voices, names, avatars) and implicit (assigned roles and behaviors) cues. We synthesize historical antecedents (e.g., telephone operators, early programmers) with case studies of dominant AI assistants (Apple’s Siri, Amazon’s Alexa, Microsoft’s Cortana) and conversational AIs (Replika, DALL·E, ChatGPT). Based on evidence from industry reports, media reports, and academic studies, we demonstrate that companies frequently justify female assistants by appealing to user preference for a “warm, trustworthy” voice. On the other hand, feminist scholars and groups warn that female-coded assistants reinforce the stereotype of women as “submissive and overly accommodating aides.” Table 2 summarizes these competing perspectives. Our interdisciplinary analysis (gender theory, Science and Technology Studies (STS), linguistics, discourse analysis) finds that these design choices have inevitable social consequences, organizing user interaction along gendered lines. Voice-perception studies confirm, for example, that users attribute nurturing qualities to female voices and authority to male voices. This article explores efforts to reverse this bias, including gender-free or adaptive virtual assistants and principles of universal design. We believe that presenting more diverse or nonbinary AI personas and developing teams with more diverse perspectives will be important towards reducing gender bias in AI design. Index Terms: AI personas, anthropomorphism, gender bias, generative AI, voice assistants

Keywords

ai agents, ai assistant, anthropomorphic, artificial intelligence, communication, networking and broadcast technologies, emerging technologies, gender bias, generative ai, technology, voice assistant

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Nigam Dave¹ and Shrishti Kushwah²

¹Affiliation not available

²Research Scholar- Pandit Deendayal Energy University

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Index Terms: *AI personas, anthropomorphism, gender bias, generative AI, voice assistants*

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II. Methodology

This study employs a qualitative and interdisciplinary methodological approach that combines historical analysis, case studies, and discourse/media analysis. The broad objective is to understand the construction and interpretation of gender in AI assistants and associated generative systems. The methodology employed is:

1. *Research Design* : We adopted qualitative case studies of leading AI systems, analyzing each system as a case representing larger trends. This aligns with Yin’s case study approach to studying “how” and “why” questions in context. We chose cases that were historically and culturally relevant like smartphone voice assistants (Siri, Alexa, Cortana, Google Assistant) released between 2011–2016, and newer generative AI services (OpenAI’s DALL-E and ChatGPT) of 2021–2022. These cases enabled comparison across companies, time, and types of technology.
2. *Data Sources* : We depended on a broad range of sources. These range from archival and historical data (e.g. telephone switchboard history and computer history), company publications (firm websites, press releases, developer guides such as Amazon’s Alexa design guides), market and survey data (e.g.

Voicebot.ai industry reports on voice use), journalistic and advocacy reports (news stories from The Atlantic, The Guardian, Reuters, National Geographic, Washington Post, etc., and NGO reports such as UNESCO’s report on voice assistants), and publications by academics (HCI and social science research on voice assistants, gender and technology, and anthropomorphism). We also checked user-generated discourse (e.g. forum and review quotes) where possible in order to incorporate consumer insights. Reviews of Replika and news coverage of women with the name “Alexa,” for example, gave insight into user reaction.

3. *Analytical Process* : We carried out thematic content and critical discourse analysis on materials we gathered. In particular, we coded design reasons and features (e.g. names, voices, personas) and critical commentary and user stories on gender. Our analysis revealed patterns of manifest gender cues (feminine names, avatars) and latent cues (assigned roles, scripted behaviors). For instance, UNESCO’s 2019 report and associated media pointed to how scripted answers like Siri’s “I’d blush if I could” insert gendered expectations, which we coded as “subservience cues”. We also tracked how companies defended their design decisions (e.g. by referencing user preference studies) and how critics pushed back (e.g. by appealing to stereotypes). The following mentioned theoretical frameworks were used to argue. Gender theory (e.g. Butler’s theory that gender is performed through repetitive acts, West & Zimmerman’s “doing gender” in technology) guided our reading of how AI behaviors “perform” femaleness; STS concepts (e.g. actor-network theory and technological script) helped us see AI assistants as socio-technical artifacts that reflect designers’ social values; and anthropomorphism research (e.g. the Media Equation by Reeves & Nass, 1996) helped explain why users attribute gender norms to voices. We particularly referred to studies demonstrating that users automatically attribute gendered features to voices, reaffirming our discourse interpretation.
4. *Case Studies and Historical Context* : Case descriptions have been organized in chronological order. We placed the phenomenon in its history first with analogues (e.g. early feminized tech roles). Then, for all AI systems, we gathered information on its name, voice, and promotion (e.g. press releases, interviews). For instance, we recorded Apple’s official words on Siri’s name and voice changes (based on The Atlantic’s report and UNESCO Q&A). For Alexa and Cortana, we relied on published interviews and company sources (e.g. Amazon’s naming spokesperson) and reputable news articles. For generative models such as DALL·E, we used recent computational bias work [27] demonstrating how their results mirror gender stereotypes. Throughout our research, we have cross-checked sources to provide validity (e.g., verifying claims with multiple sources where possible).
5. *Mixed Methods Considerations* : Apart from qualitative discourse analysis, the study uses quantitative data sources whenever possible to add evidence of user preference and gendered interaction with artificial intelligence. The research methodology includes analysis of user feedback data in great quantities from interfaces like Amazon Alexa and Apple’s Siri, where sentiment analysis provides insightful evidence of emotional response to gendered vocal characteristics. Other studies have used tools like the Valence Aware Dictionary and sEntiment Reasoner (VADER) and the BERT model to measure user sentiment, identifying evidence of gendered expectation and bias. The data sources add a quantitative dimension to the study, enabling user interactions to be classified in terms of gender-coded responses. Industry reports and user surveys of voice assistant preference, like the proportion of users who prefer the feminine voice against the neutral or masculine voice, also constitute empirical evidence. The combination of quantitative findings adds weight to the qualitative findings, thus ensuring methodological robustness of the study through the addition of tangible statistical context to the established social implications of AI gendering.

The multi-method approach incorporating qualitative case studies, historical analysis, and discourse analysis allows us to examine both the design intentions (the motivation of the company) and the social discourse surrounding them (the reception and critique) of gender in AI. Through combining conclusions from a range of fields, such as media studies, human-computer interaction (HCI), sociology, and gender studies, we form a comprehensive image of the underlying processes of the feminization of AI characters and the implications.

Our work focused mostly on Western tech companies and English-speaking contexts; cross-cultural variations

(e.g., in languages with gendered nouns) are an interesting avenue to explore. However, the strength of our qualitative findings (case histories, media analysis, and theoretical discussion) strongly suggests a gendered explanation in AI design that is consistent with long-standing social forms.

III. Results

Historical and Social Contexts

Prior to examining contemporary AI, we point to previous equivalents of gendered technology occupations. Telephone switchboard operators were virtually all females in early 20th century [19]. These women operated the physical routing of telephone calls, a position valued for its respected virtues of "tact and patience." As a historian noted, "women were the driving force behind telephony" then. Likewise, the early computer programmers in the 1940s were largely women [15]. The six women programmers of the ENIAC computer were not publicly recognized until years later. The examples below show a continued association of women with work that is both communicative and nurturing, requiring technological labor. This context suggests that designers might view coding assistants and interfaces labeled female as an extension of "natural" gender roles in technology.

Timeline of Artificial Intelligence Assistants

In this section, *Table 1* reports key generative AI and voice assistant platforms, release dates, and gender-coding. Spanning from ELIZA of the 1960s, female-named, text, no voiced assistant, to the current devices ChatGPT (2022, gender-neutral designation, text-alone), we observe that most of the conversational AIs which debuted over the last decade do have a female voice by default. High-profile examples are Apple's Siri (2011) with a woman's name (Siri, "beautiful victory" in Old Norse) and originally only a female voice; Alexa (2014, Amazon) from "Alexandria" (library) with a female voice; and Cortana (2014, Microsoft), named after a character in a Halo video game, with a female voice [28]. Google's Assistant (2016) skipped a personal name ("OK Google") but still came out with a female-sounding default voice in the U.S. (the UK one later added a male voice). It is only in recent years that companies have provided male or neutral options: for instance, Apple now allows users to select Siri's voice [29].

TABLE 1

Timeline of prominent AI conversational and generative models and gendered characters. A large majority of voice assistants default to female

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image1.emf available at <https://authorea.com/users/928336/articles/1299795-the-feminization-of-generative-ai-gender-delegation-through-names-and-personas>

IV. Case Study: Siri

Apple's Siri (launched in 2011) established an early benchmark for feminine-coded assistants. The company founders named Siri based on Old Norse meaning "beautiful victory" [28]. Apple officially acknowledged this source. When it came out, the standard voice of Siri was a female voice; in reality, Siri responds to "her" by default, and a male voice option was only introduced a number of years later. At first, Siri's pre-fabricated responses were of particular interest; a user could refer to it as "bitch" and Siri's response would come back, for instance, stating, "I'd blush if I could." [30]. That line became emblematic of the problem: critics argued that Siri's flirtatious but submissive reply normalized sexist harassment. Apple dropped that phrase (and others similar to it) from subsequent releases under pressure. By iOS 14 Apple introduced the ability to select Siri's gender (male or female) and accent, effectively ending the "female by default" policy. Despite this, Apple originally assumed that consumers preferred a female voice; a Microsoft executive noted that Apple was surprised by the backlash over Siri's gender. Nonetheless, company lore suggests that Steve Jobs insisted on keeping the feminine name. Briefly, Siri demonstrates how a female character was constructed from design beginning (name, voice, and witty feminized responses) but now has been partly rewritten as a reaction to backlash.

V. Case Study: Alexa

Amazon Alexa (2014) launched with a female persona. The name Alexa was chosen in tribute to the Library of Alexandria, representing knowledge. Amazon officials also gave technical reasons for the name: the "X" sound is unique for voice recognition. When it first launched, the Amazon Echo only used a female voice; Amazon didn't have a male voice option initially (even now, Alexa does not come with a built-in male default). This generated real-world tension. As a case in point, an interactive Washington Post feature [31] reported that women named Alexa started to resent the name's connection, and some even officially changed their names. In internal retrospectives, Amazon engineers took the mistake committed; one of them explained they had tried to "humanize" the machine, but to the detriment of other people's feelings. Amazon, as of 2022, provides a way to reset the wake word (e.g. to "Echo"), but the Alexa personality is still female. Convenience and personal preference are highlighted in user surveys and Amazon team posts. Amazon PR reported the name was "inspired by the Library of Alexandria" and was chosen for recognition. In an interview, Amazon's Alexa product leaders have referenced studies that indicate no such preference for a male or female voice among users. Indeed, it has been famously asserted by Stanford's Clifford Nass that "it is much easier to find a female voice that everyone likes." However, feminist scholars have examined such accounts. One quoted ethicist of artificial intelligence explained feminine speech as generally "cooperative, polite, and subservient" compared to masculine speech, which is "authoritative" [31]. That is, while people have a preference for female voices, critics argue that this preference is a result of social norms.

VI. Case Study Cortana and Other Assistants

Microsoft's Cortana (2014) extended this trend further. Cortana was originally the codename of a benevolent female AI character in the Halo video game franchise; Microsoft adopted the name and licensed the voice actress for the assistant. Unlike Siri and Alexa, the name "Cortana" was not selected in an effort to evoke a sense of "helpfulness," but instead was drawn from a highly established fictional figure. It did have feminine associations. The default avatar and voice of Cortana were both female in U.S. and U.K. releases. Microsoft later dropped the personalized aspect of Cortana, marketing it as a more background service but offering only female voices for the assistant.

Other platforms show the same pattern like Samsung's Bixby, released in 2017, a default female Korean voice; China's Xiao Ai, released in 2017, took on a female character; and Russia's Yandex created Alice, named and voiced as a young woman. Even when companies struggle to remove gendered names, the "default" usage will tend to default to female. Google's Assistant, released in 2016, did not include a named assistant, but its first voice for the U.S. market was female. This means that leading tech firms and international markets, personas allocated feminine traits dominating the arena of AI assistants.

VII. Implicit Gender Roles and Identities

Aside from names and voices, AI systems also possess gendered roles and characteristics. Assistant tasks such as scheduling, playing music, or sending reminders, for instance, are frequently called "service" work, which reinforces an association of women with secretary or caregiver work. When these systems interact with users, their behavior defaults to feminine stereotypes- helpful, patient, and emotionally supportive. In the Replika chatbot (2017) for companionship, we noticed that users predominantly create and interact with female-appearing companions. Users tend to define their Replika as a nurturing young woman, the same design intention of empathy and care (Although we have no published direct statistics, gender scholars notice that intimate chatbots are almost always female) [32]. Surveys of voice assistant users also suggest that both male and female test subjects tend to find artificial intelligence to be female by default unless otherwise told.

Table 2 below shows a comparison of technology companies stated design motivations (usually cited in interviews or through news releases) with critical and user-oriented views uncovered by our analysis. This contrast highlights tension between market-oriented ("female voices are more trustworthy") and social criticism ("female assistants reinforce sexism") viewpoints.

TABLE 2

Typical corporate justifications versus feminist critiques for female AI personas. Companies often cite voice “trust” (left) while critics emphasize stereotype reinforcement

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image2.emf available at <https://authorea.com/users/928336/articles/1299795-the-feminization-of-generative-ai-gender-delegation-through-names-and-personas>

VIII. Discussion

Our findings show a clear and monolithic pattern: technology designers with overwhelming consistency assign female identities to artificial intelligence assistants based on a combination of market studies and cultural assumptions. Many corporations assert that users prefer female voices by nature. For example, a study by Nass (2005) found individuals prefer female synthesized voices, a result thoroughly replicated in business surveys [33]. But based on gender theory as a conceptual framework, this trend cannot be understood in isolation. Much social psychology research (e.g., the women-are-wonderful effect and the warmth-competence tradeoff) indicates that women are culturally perceived as warm and nurturing figures.

Companies capitalize on this tendency; a representative for Microsoft cited the fact that women’s voices sound like a helpful, supportive, trustworthy assistant. But sociological critiques point to the cost within in defining the perceived helpfulness of assistants as feminine, they reinforce a servitude-women nexus. Our discourse analysis supports these theoretical predictions. The tonal and linguistic features of these assistants often embody the existing literature’s definition of warmth traits, with little assertiveness. In interviews and press engagements’ transcripts and interviews, design teams often describe female voices as a ‘friendly’ or ‘comfortable,’ using terms like ‘caring,’ ‘nurturing,’ or ‘companion’ for female artificial intelligence, unlike the scarcity in titles and roles traditionally linked with authority (such as director, CEO, etc.) in the case of these assistants. By contrast, user feedback and expert critiques offer criticism of these design decisions. UNESCO and gender experts alike explicitly warn that female assistants condition users to treat women as passive aides.

A 2019 Guardian article, quoted by UNESCO, noted that Siri’s earlier flirtatious reply to insults (“I’d blush if I could”) was the stereotype of women as dainty and easily embarrassed [20]. These tendencies mean that, in the absence of explicit designation, a female voice calls up an entire system of social meaning. Anthropomorphism is the operation involved. Experiments show that people automatically map human social categories onto computer voices. For instance, Tolmeijer et al. [34] discovered that listening to a voice already makes people attribute gender and gendered characteristics nearly automatically. Within this debate, the use of a female voice by a piece of artificial intelligence encourages listeners to place it within dominant stereotypes. Critics suggest that organizations do not circumvent such stereotypes by providing their assistants with female voices; rather, they reinforce them. According to Alexa Hagerty, due to female voice assistants being seen as “subservient,” users end up commanding them in a condescending tone, thereby further solidifying the normalization of sexism within this technological context. A Science and Technology Studies (STS) analysis brings out how these gender decisions are socially created. Every design choice – from naming to voice choice – is a socio-technical decision that carries the biases of its designers. For instance, male-dominated design groups (as the majority have been) may inadvertently default to female personas due to earlier gender hierarchies in their tradition. Even engineering justifications are the result of social conceptions. Amazon’s selection of the feminine name “Alexa” was partly a technical choice (lab-friendly, distinctive phonemes) but partly an homage to earlier norms of female aides (library’s “knowledge”). At the same time, Google’s bypassing of a female name (using a gender-neutral “Assistant”) implies some awareness of the concern, but the designers still retained a female-sounding default voice for familiarity.

This is in line with the idea that technology “scripts” are co-creating identity: the assistant is introduced as a supporting actor in this script, and users then act out that role. Gender analysis also draws on the theory of performing gender [35] that gender is not an essential quality but an enactment through habitual practices. An AI that is soft-spoken, compliant, and has a female voice successfully performs the identity of “woman” as constructed by modern cultural norms. An assistant like Alexa or Siri therefore does not just have a gender

– it actively performs one. Our research suggests that these performed identities repeatedly resonate with established cultural archetypes (female = caring, accommodating; male = authoritative, and less often within these systems). Surprisingly, we discovered that even gender-neutral systems are not bias-free. DALL·E’s is a classic example, even though it has no voice or name, the images it produces are stereotypically gendered. In one test, almost all CEO images were men, while “nurse” predominantly depicted women.

This evidence suggests that both training sets and human-crafted prompts will have inherent stereotypes. In practice, users of DALL·E inadvertently reinforce gender bias by default. ChatGPT and other large language models are deployed without a particular gender; however, any vocal demonstrations or conversational modalities can be interpreted as more masculine or feminine unless developers actively choose neutrality. Google’s Bard was even initially thought of as a female “assistant,” leading engineers to defend its neutrality. Together, our analysis suggests that feminization of artificial intelligence is not so much a branding error but a deeply entrenched issue based on gender expectations. The tension of “user preference” vs. “harmful bias” argument in *Table 2* captures this tension. On one hand, companies cite data that a high proportion of users will have a preference for female voices, with research, such as Nass’s study, establishing an inherent preference for these voices.

Conversely, experts contend that such tendencies are culturally created and that the preference to favor females perpetuates systemic injustice. From the ethical perspective, most have maintained, concurring with UNESCO, that there is no technical need for female gender for assistants.

A) Technology-Driven Solutions to Mitigate Gender Bias in AI

To efficiently address the age-old issue of gender bias in artificial intelligence, several technology-driven methodologies can be employed. One of the most feasible methods is developing adaptive voice algorithms that alter vocal characteristics based on user choice or contextual cues, as opposed to a pre-defined gender representation. For instance, recent advancements in neural voice synthesis and deep learning architectures enable real-time alteration of pitch, tone, and speech patterns, thus creating more personalized and contextually sensitive interactions. Another cutting-edge method is the use of real-time gender-neutral voice modulation, where AI systems interact without perpetuating gendered assumptions. This is enabled by technologies like generative adversarial networks (GANs) and speech synthesis models committed to acoustical neutrality and emotional tone consistency. Additionally, synthetic, non-human voice profiles provide another solution by removing human-like gender connotations altogether, emphasizing the functional and technical aspect of artificial intelligence. For instance, projects like Virtue Nordic’s “Q” prototype have provided gender-neutral voices that bypass conventionally gendered pitch ranges, thus offering an even, non-binary user experience. The use of such solutions not only removes bias but also represents a more inclusive approach in digital design, in line with ethical principles of artificial intelligence and improving user-centered interaction.

IX. Conclusion

The evidence shows that the “feminization” of AI assistants is an intentional, historically grounded design phenomenon with material implications. Major technology companies have routinely provided female personas for their generative AI agents, typically in the name of technical convenience or user preference.

However, feminist analyses and our inter-disciplinary perspective demonstrate that these choices include stereotypes of women as servitors in the technology. In other words, when Siri, Alexa, or Replika acts like a helpful young woman, it legitimates the idea that women’s role is to please and serve. This raises urgent questions about the ethics of anthropomorphizing artificially intelligent entities. Should artificial actors be compelled to have voices and personalities, designers should consider non-traditional options. As UNESCO suggests, there is no requirement that assistants default to a female gender. Some firms have started providing male or alternative voices (Apple’s latest Siri upgrade is a good start), but these are exceptions. To avoid perpetuating bias, a more radical solution is needed: using gender-neutral voices or even more symbolic figures. Inclusive guidelines and diverse teams can help counteract this. For instance, Amazon’s own revised “Alexa Ethics Guidelines” comment on the irony of saying “she” when talking of Alexa while asserting no gender; they invite designers to make these decisions thoughtfully. Reducing AI gender bias is itself part

of a larger project to institute equity in technology. If our results are true, then as increasingly pervasive generative AI finds its way (into homes, cars, devices, and media), it is essential to disrupt the default female gendering of digital assistants. Adopting flexible, multi-voice systems or consciously non-human avatars could untangle service from femininity. In addition, educating the public that "assistant = woman" is a design decision, not fate, can reshape expectations. By making AI design more intentional regarding gender implications, we move toward a future in which technology neither favors nor burdens any gender.

X. Future Scope

In the realm of future research, it is essential that future research expands on this corpus of research by advancing this field through interdisciplinary research collaboration between computer scientists, social scientists, and digital ethicists. These studies need to go beyond descriptive analysis to include empirical tests of how different design choices about voice affect user perceptions, interactions, and long-term behavioral effects. Such studies could include controlled experiments of user reactions to gender-neutral or adaptive voice assistants, and longitudinal studies of the social impacts of such designs over months or years. Research on the development of algorithmic tools to detect and correct bias in voice synthesis has the potential to greatly improve the ethical priorities of artificial intelligence systems. The integration of technical expertise in machine learning and natural language processing with socio-cultural insight from the social sciences will be key to the development of truly inclusive AI systems. Moreover, such interdisciplinary approaches will be key to the mission of ensuring that future AI technologies do more than merely avoid reproducing current biases, and instead promote diversity and inclusion in human-machine interaction.

CONFLICT OF INTEREST

The authors declare that there are no conflicts of interest regarding the publication of this paper. The research was conducted without any financial or commercial relationships that could be construed as a potential conflict of interest.

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Prof. (Dr.) Nigam Dave was born in India. He received the B.A. in English Literature from Gujarat University, and M.A. and Ph.D. in English Literature from Bhavnagar University, India. His major field

of study is English literature, with a focus on children's literature, adolescent fiction, the intersection of artificial intelligence and children's development, and healthy parenting practices.

He has held various academic and administrative positions at Pandit Deendayal Energy University (PDEU), Gandhinagar, India, including serving as the Founding Dean (2010–2020) and Founding Director (2015–2024) of the School of Liberal Studies. He is currently the Dean of the Office of International Relations at PDEU. Prof. Dave has over 32 years of academic and research experience and has guided seven Ph.D. scholars to completion.



Ms. Shrishti Kushwah was born in India. She received the B.A. and M.A. degrees in English Literature from Gujarat University, India, in 2018 and 2020, respectively, and is currently pursuing the Ph.D. degree in English from Pandit Deendayal Energy University (PDEU), Gandhinagar, India. Her major field of study is children's literature, focusing on early childhood education, narratology, and digital storytelling.

She has worked as a Visiting Faculty at Pandit Deendayal Energy University (PDEU), Gandhinagar, where she taught English Communication. She was also a Teaching Assistant. She has presented research papers at national and international conferences, exploring themes such as the intersection of artificial intelligence and literature, digital transformations in storytelling, and ethical implications for young readers. Her current research interests include digital branching narratives, parenting perspectives, and the impact of AI on children's literature.